

MANDAR DEODHAR



THIS WAY, THAT WAY NCP(SP) chief Sharad Pawar with daughter and Baramati MP Supriya Sule; (inset) the estranged Ajit Pawar

▶ MAHARASHTRA

CEASEFIRE IN PAWAR LAND?

Sharad Pawar sets speculation swirling with hints of 'two views' in his party. One favours a reunion of the two NCPs. Daughter Supriya clearly says no

Known for his unpredictable but always shrewd chess moves, Pawar's words only whetted the appetite of political punters, offering nothing to sate it. Speaking to INDIA TODAY, Sule refused them even crumbs. She said she had "not even thought about it (a reunion)", that "there has been no discussion", and that Pawar Sr had "clearly indicated (that) he is where he is". She may not be party to it, but there indeed exists a point of view that differs from hers. For one, Pawar's grand nephew Rohit, one of only 10 survivors in the NCP(SP)'s assembly poll washout in 2024, has openly urged the seniors to sue for peace.

"Any reconciliation will be a win-win for both parties," says another senior. His line entails shifting out of the block—i.e. the INDIA bloc. The NCP(SP)'s cohort of eight Lok Sabha MPs, he says, could add to Ajit's clout in New Delhi (the latter's NCP has just one LS MP), helping him upstage his rival deputy CM Eknath Shinde, whose Shiv Sena has seven LS MPs. "It's easier for the Pawars to reunite," he says. "The estrangement is just two years old. It hasn't yet ossified among the rank and file." The MPs and legislators, he adds, are suffering from "exclusion" in the grant of development funds, citing how even Sule had to go on a hunger strike to get a road repaired in her constituency.

Another NCP(SP) leader speaks of 'three views' in the party—the third being merging with the Congress, a diminution of leadership being the only danger. As for an NCP reconciliation, his timeline strictly defers any chance for it past the Bihar election and Maharashtra's local body polls.

Takeaways

- **Sharad Pawar frankly says some in NCP(SCP) want a patch-up with Ajit's NCP**
- **Grand nephew Rohit Pawar, strong local lobbies are some of the votaries**

It's a lobby with a strong presence in the cooperatives and education sector that favours a reunion, says a source (hinting at the presence of another group that thinks a non-fuzzy secular line would deliver results by 2029). The flurry of whispers began after four MLAs from Solapur reached out to Pawar via state chief Jayant Patil, advocating a stake in power. A top leader says Pawar may have been spurred to speak due to this pressure from within to prevent a further split. However, like a master of the old ball, his seam was pointed towards the wind but no one could properly see which side the shine was on. ■